GRE Quantitative Comparison Practice Pack

The 4 Standard Answer Choices, The D-Option Protocol, Number Testing Strategies & Geometric Traps

1. The 4 Standard Answer Choices & Operational Mindset

Quantitative Comparison (QC) questions constitute over 35% of the GRE Quant section. Memorize the 4 immutable answer choices.

Answer Choice Option	Exact Mathematical Meaning	When to Choose This Option	When to Immediately Eliminate
(A) Quantity A is greater	Quantity A is strictly greater than Quantity B under EVERY possible case	Proven mathematically or tested across all boundary cases	Eliminate the moment Quantity B is equal or greater in ANY single case
(B) Quantity B is greater	Quantity B is strictly greater than Quantity A under EVERY possible case	Proven algebraically or tested across all boundary cases	Eliminate the moment Quantity A is equal or greater in ANY single case
(C) The two quantities are equal	Quantity A strictly equals Quantity B under EVERY possible scenario	Both quantities simplify algebraically to the exact same value	Eliminate the moment you find even one case where they differ
(D) The relationship cannot be determined	The relationship shifts depending on the values chosen (e.g. A > B in case 1, but A = B in case 2)	Two valid test cases yield contradictory relationships	NEVER choose (D) if both quantities contain only fixed, concrete numbers!

Fundamental Rule: If both Quantity A and Quantity B contain pure numbers with no variables, (D) is mathematically impossible.

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2. The "ZONEF" Number Testing Protocol

When testing numbers in QC questions, test these 5 distinct mathematical zones to uncover hidden shifts.

ZONEF Number Category	Numbers to Test	Mathematical Property It Tests	Common QC Trap It Exposes
Z – Zero (0)	x = 0	Neutral element for addition; collapses multiplication to 0	Exposes when x^2 = 0 while x can be positive or negative
O – One (1)	x = 1	Neutral element for multiplication; powers of 1 stay 1	Exposes exponent traps (1^3 = 1^2)
N – Negatives	x = -1, -2, -10	Negative bases flip inequality signs and behave differently with even/odd powers	(-2)^2 = +4, but (-2)^3 = -8
E – Extremes	x = 100, 1000	Reveals asymptotic growth trends in polynomial expressions	Higher-degree polynomials dominate constants at extreme values
F – Fractions (Between 0 and 1)	x = 1/2, 1/4	Fractions get SMALLER when squared and LARGER when square-rooted!	(1/2)^2 = 1/4 (which is LESS than 1/2!)

Golden Strategy: If Case 1 gives A > B and Case 2 gives A = B, stop calculating immediately—the answer is 100% (D).

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3. High-Frequency Geometric and Algebraic QC Traps

ETS psychometricians design subtle traps to exploit test-taker assumptions.

- Trap 1: The "Not Drawn to Scale" Optical Illusion. Never assume an angle is 90 degrees or lines are equal based on visual appearance unless explicitly stated.
- Trap 2: Hidden Secondary Roots. In equations like x^2 = 25, x can be +5 OR -5. If Quantity B is 5, the relationship cannot be determined (D).
- Trap 3: Inequality Division by Unknowns. Never divide or multiply both sides of an inequality by variable x unless you know its sign with 100% certainty.
- Trap 4: Simplification Before Testing. Always subtract identical terms or divide by positive constants from both quantities before testing numbers.